Crossway Bible Church
Divorce and Remarriage Position Statement

This position statement is intended to communicate *to those who are members of Crossway Bible Church* how we *as the elders* would *think about and consider situations as they come up among us as a church*. We intend this to be used as an explanation, not a try-it-at-home recipe for handling divorce and remarriage, disconnected from biblical shepherding and care.

Please understand, we as elders want you to understand the Scriptures most pertinent to the issues of divorce and remarriage, and we want you to know how, generally, we would counsel, lead, and discipline in such situations.

Sometimes, out of an authentic desire for clarity, we are tempted to say more than God does, less than God does, or even avoid some of the nuances God intended to reveal. We will too often want more specificity than God gave us. Thus, the question we always begin with is, "What does the Scripture *SAY*?" followed closely by a second, "What did God, therefore, *MEAN?*" It's vital that we believe that both of those questions are more important than any of the questions we bring to any particular text.

Each situation is best handled in turn, in context, and under the protection of those entrusted to oversee Christ's flock. This statement is not a "do it yourself" manual on divorce and remarriage. It's an outline of biblical principles and a call to value the protection of those keeping watch over your soul.

You will find this statement divided into three parts: 1) a brief discussion of the four basic stances on the topic at hand, including a brief explanation of the view our elders hold and teach, 2) several relevant Scripture passages that are major forks in the road to help get to clarity, 3) and some practical "But What About…?" explanations of some frequently asked questions that require some special attention.

FOUR BASIC STANCES

No Divorce, therefore, No Remarriage

Those who see marriage as an unconditionally life-long covenant are less likely to harmonize the verses that seem to imply an exception to that rule. Those who hold to

this position argue that Scripture only positively speaks to remarriage after a person's spouse has died, and that would be the only permissible situation for remarriage to occur.
They do not all hold the same interpretation of the "exception passages" in Matt 5 and 19, and in 1 Cor 7 that are often cited as situations that would produce a "biblically permissible divorce." However, they remain unconvinced that these situations would be either full-fledged covenantal marriages (such as the case between Mary & Joseph while they were engaged but not yet married), or that the result of being abandoned by an unbeliever would render the marriage covenant no longer binding.

As John Piper has famously written, "The ultimate meaning of marriage is the representation of the covenant-keeping love between Christ and his church…Therefore, if Christ ever abandons and discards his church, then a man may divorce his wife" (Piper, *This Momentary Marriage*, p.159).

Advocates of this position, with room for nuance, are: John Piper, F. F. Bruce, and James Montgomery Boice.

Narrow Divorce, No Remarriage

Those who are convinced that verses such as Matthew 5:32 and/or 1 Corinthians 7:10-15 do constitute the two fallen-world exceptions to God's design for marriage as a lifelong covenantal union, still fall into two camps: the first of which would argue that Scripture does not explicitly permit the offended party in a biblically permissible divorce to remarry. Even if the divorce could be biblically defended in such cases, such people are not thereby free to marry again while their spouse is living.

Gordon Wenham's argument unfolds in four stages. First, the early church fathers almost unanimously rejected remarriage after divorce the first five centuries of the church. Further, the rest of the NT outside of Matthew, when it speaks of remarriage, only condones it after the death of a spouse. Third, the passages in Matthew can be interpreted to mean that divorce (except for *porneia*) is adultery, that remarriage (even in the case of *porneia*) is still adultery. Finally, the prevailing understanding of divorce and remarriage in the Judaism of Jesus' day aligns with the "permissible divorce allows for permissible remarriage," and Wenham maintains that it would be more likely that Jesus taught *against* the prevailing wisdom of His day. (Wenham in *Remarriage After Divorce in Today's Church: 3 Views*, p.19-42)

Advocates of this position, once again, with room for nuance, are: Gordon Wenham and Robert Gundry.

Wide Circumstances for Divorce and Remarriage

Further, there are those who would argue that the "exceptions" from Matthew and 1 Corinthians are best considered as "categories" that would inform biblically-minded Christians as to the kinds of offenses that lead to a marriage covenant that is already broken, and thus would only be *confirmed* by an actual divorce.

Craig Keener's stance rests first on the hyperbolic nature of Jesus' sayings in the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5). He affirms that, "*the tenor of New Testament teaching…is that divorce is to be avoided at all costs…Assuming that Jesus' teaching on the subject is a general principle meant to admit exceptions (as Matthew and Paul demonstrate), and acknowledging the probability that his teaching is hyperbolic, we may allow some exceptions not addressed by Matthew or Paul because they were not specifically relevant to the situations these writers addressed*" (Keener, *…And Marries Another: Divorce and Remarriage in the Teaching of the New Testament*, 105).

Advocates of this position, with nuance, are: Craig Keener, and Larry Richards.

Narrow Divorce, Narrow Remarriage (Crossway Bible Church's Position)

We hold that there are two situations that could lead to a biblically permissible divorce: sexual immorality (*pornea*) in Matthew 5, and the abandonment of a believer by an unbeliever in 1 Corinthians 7. We further believe abuse is a kind of abandonment (see "But what about abuse?" below). Most interpreters would hold that if a divorce is biblically permissible, the offended believer would then be free to remarry.

We are convinced that the permissibility of divorce, given the context of first-century Judaism, where divorce would have been legally effected by a document stating "You are free to remarry…" assumes the permissibility of remarriage (Stein, "Divorce" *Dictionary of Jesus and the Gospels*, 195). Further, the interpretation of Matt 19:9 regarding divorce and remarriage is convincingly summarized by D. A. Carson as: "*Anyone who divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery—though this principle does not hold in the case of porneia*" (Carson, *Matthew*, 416).

Proponents of this position, other than our elders, are: Craig Blomberg, D. A. Carson, Robert Stein, and John Frame.

Relevant Scripture Passages

Matthew 5:32 and Luke 16:18

> *But I say to you that everyone who divorces his wife, except on the ground of sexual immorality, makes her commit adultery, and whoever marries a divorced woman commits adultery*. (Matt 5:32)
>
> *Everyone who divorces his wife and marries another commits adultery, and he who marries a woman divorced from her husband commits adultery*. (Lk 16:18)

Both of these passages speak particularly to remarriage after divorce, but Matthew's account verbalizes what's known as the "exception clause" regarding sexual immorality (*porneia*). The similarity of these statements leads an interpreter to want to harmonize or at least handle them at the same time. They imply:

- (Re)marriage after an illicit divorce is adulterous.
- Marrying someone who was illicitly divorced is adulterous.
- Divorcing someone for an illegitimate reason makes them vulnerable to adultery, since it was expected, especially at that time, that they would then need to remarry to survive.
- Sexual immorality is an exception that makes divorce and its impact permissible.

Thus, the situation that warranted instruction in the context of these two sayings was: "What happens when a person divorces his wife other than on the grounds of sexual immorality?" And the instruction Jesus gives is that the marriage covenant is not "canceled" by merely divorcing someone for any reason. A commitment to the marriage covenant remains, and it must be upheld, unless or until it is broken by sexual immorality.

Matthew 19:3-9 and Mark 10:2-12

> *3 And Pharisees came up to him and tested him by asking, "Is it lawful to divorce*
> *one's wife for any cause?" 4 He answered, "Have you not read that he who*
> *created them from the beginning made them male and female, 5 and said,*
> *'Therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother and hold fast to his wife,*
> *and the two shall become one flesh'? 6 So they are no longer two but one flesh.*
> *What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate." 7 They said to*
> *him, "Why then did Moses command one to give a certificate of divorce and to*

send her away?" [8] He said to them, "Because of your hardness of heart Moses allowed you to divorce your wives, but from the beginning it was not so. [9] And I say to you: whoever divorces his wife, except for sexual immorality, and marries another, commits adultery." (Matt 19:3-9)

[2] And Pharisees came up and in order to test him asked, "Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife?" [3] He answered them, "What did Moses command you?" [4] They said, "Moses allowed a man to write a certificate of divorce and to send her away." [5] And Jesus said to them, "Because of your hardness of heart he wrote you this commandment. [6] But from the beginning of creation, 'God made them male and female.' [7] 'Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and hold fast to his wife, [8] and the two shall become one flesh.' So they are no longer two but one flesh. [9] What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate." [10] And in the house the disciples asked him again about this matter. [11] And he said to them, "Whoever divorces his wife and marries another commits adultery against her, [12] and if she divorces her husband and marries another, she commits adultery." (Mk 10:2-12)

These passages speak to the questions of lawfulness of divorce "for any cause." Though each passage has particular nuances, they are similar enough that we can surmise:

- The marriage covenant creates a "one flesh" union between husband and wife.
- Divorce is the man-made separation of this God-formed union, and was a concession God allowed Moses to make because of the people's hardness of heart.
- Divorce was not a practice that pleased the Lord (though Matthew again has the caveat exception for sexual immorality).
- Man should not aim to separate what God has joined together in marriage.
- The sexual union implied by a new marriage after an illicit divorce constitutes adultery.

Once again, only Matthew has the "exception clause" regarding sexual immorality. Yet, we are convinced that these two passages are in harmony with one another and both are to form our counsel and obedience. Whatever the context, even if divorce is permitted by the clear instruction of Jesus, it should be regarded by those who love Him as desirable as amputation of a diseased limb, or excision of aggressive brain cancer. Even permissible divorce separates what God joined together in response to heinous evil.

1 Corinthians 7:10-15

> *10 To the married I give this charge (not I, but the Lord): the wife should not separate from her husband 11 (but if she does, she should remain unmarried or else be reconciled to her husband), and the husband should not divorce his wife. 12 To the rest I say (I, not the Lord) that if any brother has a wife who is an unbeliever, and she consents to live with him, he should not divorce her. 13 If any woman has a husband who is an unbeliever, and he consents to live with her, she should not divorce him. 14 For the unbelieving husband is made holy because of his wife, and the unbelieving wife is made holy because of her husband. Otherwise your children would be unclean, but as it is, they are holy. 15 But if the unbelieving partner separates, let it be so. In such cases the brother or sister is not enslaved. God has called you to peace. 16 For how do you know, wife, whether you will save your husband? Or how do you know, husband, whether you will save your wife?* (1 Cor 7:10-15)

This passage speaks to what a believer is to do if their *unbelieving* spouse separates from or leaves them. Though the word “divorce” is not present in the text, when the unbelieving partner *separates*, divorce is implied, especially given the way he speaks of “consenting to live with” in verse 13 as the opposite of divorce. Paul’s encouragement to the one who is abandoned is that they are not *enslaved*, implying:

- The believing spouse cannot appeal to their spouse’s unbelief as grounds for divorce.
- If the unbelieving partner separates, effecting a divorce, “the brother or sister is not enslaved.”
- The abandoned believer, no longer “bound” or “enslaved” to their former marriage, would by implication be “free” to marry another.

Note that 1 Cor 7 comes not long after Paul’s specific instruction to the church regarding what they are to do to the unrepentant sexually immoral brother (1 Cor 5:1-13). Paul commands them to discipline them, to “purge” them from the congregation to protect the purity and witness of the church in the world. The standards for believers and unbelievers are different in these respects then: the believer may not separate because their spouse is an unbeliever, though it seems correct to say that if one spouse professes to be a believer but is disciplined out of the church, they could then be in the category of the abandoning unbeliever in 1 Cor 7.

Remarriage After Divorce

The clearest passages in the New Testament about a person being free to remarry is after the death of their spouse (Rom 7:2-3; 1 Cor 7:39). Add to that the fact that in two of the above passages - Mark 10:11 and Luke 16:18 – the only time remarriage is mentioned, it is spoken of as adultery.

Perhaps it is best, given the exception clauses in Matthew and First Corinthians, to think of the stark nature of Jesus' words in those two situations in contrast to the prevailing practice of divorcing one's wife "for any reason" and then marrying another. Since there *are* exceptions, then Jesus' not mentioning them in Mark and Luke does seem to strongly highlight the nature of the principle rather than the exceptions.

Yet, the only Scriptures that specifically allow for remarriage do so after the death of the spouse. It takes some biblical-theological synthesis to say that the exceptions of sexual immorality and abandonment by an unbeliever imply that remarriage would then be allowable. We have no single Scripture verse which explicitly says that.

Nonetheless, it seems wise to conclude that divorces that are biblically allowable would lead to biblically allowable remarriage.

That is not to say that anyone who is divorced would be eligible for remarriage. The statements on remarriage in Mark, Luke, and Paul's letters still mean *something*. For instance, if a divorcee's former spouse is still living, and their divorce was not biblically legitimate, it would not be permissible for them to remarry someone other than their former spouse. According to Jesus, divorcing your spouse and marrying someone else would be *adultery* (see Matt 19:9 and Mk 2:11-12).

It would be the same if you divorced your spouse in a biblically illicit way and then *they* got remarried to someone else: this would be how you would cause *them* to commit adultery (see Matt 5:32).

Frequently Asked Questions: But what about…?

But what about if I remarried and I shouldn't have?

Short answer: this, like every other sin of those who trust in Jesus, is nailed to the cross! Your current marriage is the marriage you should stay committed to, regardless of how it began or whether it was a faithful one to step into.

Longer answer: in time and in the context of your church community, you will need to wrestle with how and if you have faced the reality of that sin, and repented of it to God and if advisable, to your (ex-) spouse as well. You might be concerned about how you will be perceived by others in the church. It's heartbreaking to hear how some people who have been divorced have been treated by others who profess faith in Jesus. No Christian has a right to hold divorce, permissible or not, over your head in petty judgment.

You should also know that the enemy will try to hang it over your head and over your marriage and family for as long as you'll let him. So don't let him!

Pray for clarity and for the strength to repent fully and as widely as you should, and trust that Christ really covered it when He took the record of sin that stood against us and set it aside, nailing it to the cross. Even if others mistreat or judge you for sin you can't undo, Jesus' cross ensures you no longer face the penalty for sin (see Col 2:6-15)!

But what about if I've remained single and my (ex-) spouse remarried?

Short answer: though it's possible that you could be eligible for remarriage, this situation is more fragile and less cut-and-dry than it might seem.

Longer answer: If we assume that your original divorce would not have been biblically permissible, you separated from a one-flesh marriage union that God Himself brought together, and put your spouse and yourself in a place where your single-minded devotion to holy celibacy in the Lord would have been challenged.

They were remarried, true, and it very well could be that Scripture calls that new union adultery, but you had a role in that as well.

The sin of illegitimate divorce has to be acknowledged and repented of before the Lord and where possible, before the (ex-) spouse as well. Yet, since the marriage covenant has now been broken by adultery, you might be free to remarry.

There may be freedom here, but there's definitely a need for wisdom, and you would do well to be shepherded closely if this is your situation.

But what if we want to be reconciled?

Short answer: Whenever possible, reconciliation should be pursued after an illegitimate divorce.

Longer answer: Those who are pursuing reconciliation after an illegitimate divorce from one another, should *not* simply continue participating in married life as usual unless and until they are again *legally* bound in marriage. The legal act doesn't mean *nothing*, it just doesn't mean *everything*.

But what about if I've been abandoned by a professing believer?

Short answer: just because someone professes to be a believer does not mean that they are, and careful consideration must be taken to discern the salvation of the abandon*er* on a case-by-case basis.

Longer answer: this is one of many reasons that you need a church, and you need shepherd-hearted pastors and disciple-makers to help you discern the edges of a situation that will be fraught with your own desires, the complications of hearsay and gossip, and the brokenness of living in the aftermath of shattered dreams you didn't sign up for. We need the church to help us discern and faithfully respond in a situation like this, because it's never as simple as it might seem.

But what about abuse?

God hates all forms of oppression, abuse, and misuse of the vulnerable, and so should all who are being saved.

Our heart breaks for and with you over what you have suffered.

We want to help however you will allow us.

If you are coming to a realization about a past pattern of abuse, we are eager to see you restored and healed, and would be honored to walk with

you through this process. If you are being abused *now* and are looking for help, we are eager to help get you to a place of safety. Please reach out to your Small Group Leader as soon as practicable to find help. If you are unsure about whether what you have experienced is abuse, consider some of the warning signs here from *Called to Peace Ministries*, with whom we partner as a church. If you are unsure of what resources would be available to you in our area, you will find a list and contact information for local and national resources in our Safety Plan.

Our response to this issue has developed in recent years, and prompted a statement of its own, which you can see here (needs a link, once we public our statement on Abuse).

We intend to listen to, take seriously, support, and care for those affected by abuse of any kind.

When abuse is suspected, we intend to take each situation seriously as leaders and as a church that cares well for the oppressed and vulnerable. The first concern in a conversation about abuse of any kind is the safety of those in the path of those vulnerable to the oppressor. Whether that person is an abused spouse, children, elderly, or other vulnerable adult, we intend to first help them get to a place of safety and have any conversations about the "fallout" relating to a marriage later.

We believe there are kinds and levels of abuse or oppression that effectively constitute "constructive abandonment" – meaning that though the unrepentant abuser does not abandon the home, they actively construct a situation in which those vulnerable to their violence are forced to flee (often with their children) to find safety and *peace* (see 1 Cor 7:15b) (See also Frame, *Doctrine of the Christian Life*, 780-781).

In such a situation, which can only be determined on a case-by-case basis, divorce could be permissible under the principle derived from First Corinthians 7:15 and 1 Corinthians 5. Professing believers submit to the discipline of the church and her elders. One who persists in unrepentance should be lovingly disciplined - and may ultimately be disfellowshipped and treated as an unbeliever (see Matthew 18:17 and 1 Corinthians 5:11-13).

But what about if I was divorced before I became a Christian?

Short answer: at issue is the permanence of a one-flesh union; the question of whether a person is a Christian or not is not the only relevant detail, as though any divorce effected before you became a Christian "doesn't count."

Longer answer: marriage is a one-flesh lifelong covenantal union created by God and is intended for those who are in Christ and those who are not - those who are Christians and those who are not.

The permanence and lifelong design of the marriage covenant is built into God's design for marriage, no matter who enters into it. If a person realizes after they become a Christian that they were unbiblically divorced, they should: 1) repent of their sin to God and if possible their (ex-) spouse, and 2) ascertain the possibility of reconciliation of the marriage.

As in every other case, that should be pursued alongside your Small Group Leaders and your pastors, so that you can be shepherded! One more reason that we desperately need the church!

But what about pornography use?

Short answer: sustained, significant, unrepentant pornography use could constitute the kind of sexual immorality that would render a divorce permissible, but consider this with *caution* and a commitment to be *shepherded* through it!

Longer answer: with the ubiquitous access of pornography available to this generation, "pornography use" has to be understood and taken seriously on a case-by-case basis.

We would not be alone in saying that there are cases of pornography use that could constitute grounds of divorce, such as when it is practiced dangerously and/or unrepentantly becomes a substitute for married sex (See Frame, *Doctrine of the Christian Life*, 775). But not every single situation would do so.

This, again, is a situation where we need the church, our small group leaders and fellow members, our elders, counselors, and other leaders to

help us discern the situation and prayerfully consider and call one another to a faithful path forward.

But what about if my situation isn't on this list?

That's why we all need the church! Longer answer: realistically, no one's complete situation will be captured on an FAQ like this because there is nuance in each of our stories. Nevertheless, it would have a great impact on and encourage the church to walk beside each person *in* their journey, despite how broken each of us is, to help each other grow in Christlikeness and faithfulness. We all need the church!

Conclusion

God designed marriage to be between one man and one woman for as long as they both live. Because of the hardness of heart brought about by sin, God permits divorce in the narrow circumstances of sexual immorality and abandonment by an unbeliever. As Jesus' disciples, we are committed to rightly handling Scripture which calls us to faithfully teach people to obey everything that Jesus commanded, even when it's messy. We are made to be a part of a local church that eagerly submits to godly shepherding under the Great Shepherd, Jesus Christ.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Beale, G. K., and D. A. Carson, eds. *Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament*. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, Apollos, 2007.

Blomberg, Craig L. "Marriage, Divorce, Remarriage, and Celibacy: An Exegesis of Matthew 19:3-12." *Trinity Journal* 11, no. 2 (September 1990): 161–96.

———. *Matthew*. The New American Commentary, vol. 21. Nashville: Broadman and Holman, 1992.

Bruner, Frederick Dale. *Matthew: Volume 2, The Churchbook Mathew 13-28*. Vol. 2. 2 vols. Dallas: Word Pub, 1990.

Christensen, Duane L., David A. Hubbard, Glenn W. Barker, Bruce M. Metzger, and Duane L. Christensen. *Deuteronomy 21:10-34:12*. Word Biblical Commentary, [General ed.: David A. Hubbard; Glenn W. Barker. Old Testament ed.: John D. W. Watts. New Testament ed.: Ralph P. Martin] ; Vol. 6, Waco, TX: Word Books, 2002.

Danker, Frederick W., Walter Bauer, and William Arndt. *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature*. 3rd ed. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000.

"Divorce & Remarriage: A Position Paper." *Desiring God*, July 21, 1986. http://www.desiringgod.org/articles/divorce-remarriage-a-position-paper.

Gaebelein, Frank E., ed. *Isaiah-Ezekiel; The Expositor's Bible Commentary with the New International Version of the Holy Bible*. Vol. 6. 12 vols. Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1990.

———. *Matthew, Mark, Luke; The Expositor's Bible Commentary with the New International Version of the Holy Bible*. Vol. 8. 12 vols. Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1984.

Grudem, Wayne. *What the Bible Says About Divorce and Remarriage*. Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2021.

Instone-Brewer, David. "1 Corinthians 7 in the Light of the Jewish Greek and Aramaic Marriage and Divorce Papyri." *Tyndale Bulletin* 52, no. 2 (2001): 225–43.

———. *Divorce and Remarriage in the Bible: The Social and Literary Context*. Grand Rapids: W.B. Eerdmans, 2002.

Isaksson, Abel. *Marriage and Ministry in the New Temple: A Study with Special Reference to Mt. 19.3-12 and 1 Cor. 11.3-16*. Ejnar Munksgaard Copenhagen: CWK Gleerup Lund, 1965.

Köstenberger, Andreas J., and David W. Jones. *God, Marriage, and Family: Rebuilding the Biblical Foundation*. 2nd ed. Wheaton, Ill: Crossway, 2010.

Keener, Craig. *...And Marries AnotherL Divorce and Remarriage in the teaching of the New Testament*. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 1991.

Mathews, K. A. *Genesis*. The New American Commentary, vol. 1. Nashville: Broadman and Holman, 1995.

Merrill, Eugene H. *Deuteronomy*. The New American Commentary, vol. 4. Nashville: Broadman and Holman, 1994.

Murray, John. *Divorce*. Phillipsburg, New Jersey: Presbyterian and Reformed Publiching Company, 1961.

Newheiser, Jim. *Marriage, Divorce, and Remarriage: Critical Questions and Answers*. Phillipsburg, New Jersey: P&R Publishing, 2017.

Piper, John. *This Momentary Marriage: A Parable of Permanence*. Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway, 2012.

Ross, Allen P. *Creation and Blessing: A Guide to the Study and Exposition of Genesis*. 1st ed. Grand Rapids: Baker Book House, 1996.

Stein, Robert H. "'Is It Lawful for a Man to Divorce His Wife.'" *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 22, no. 2 (June 1979): 115–21.

———. "Divorce" In Joel Green and I. Howard Marshall Eds. *Dictionary of Jesus and the Gospels*. Downers Grove, Illinois: InterVarsity Press, 1992.

Thiselton, Anthony C. *The First Epistle to the Corinthians: A Commentary on the Greek Text*. The New International Greek Testament Commentary, vol. 7. Grand Rapids: W.B. Eerdmans, 2000.

Wenham, Gordon J, and William A. Heth. *Jesus and Divorce*. Carlisle: Paternoster Press, 2002.

Wenham, Gordon J., David A. Hubbard, Glenn W. Barker, Bruce M. Metzger, and Gordon J. Wenham. *Genesis 1 - 15*. Word Biblical Commentary, [General ed.: David A. Hubbard; Glenn W. Barker. Old Testament ed.: John D. W. Watts. New Testament ed.: Ralph P. Martin] ; vol. 1. Waco, TX: Word Books, 1987.